

*Haligric Research Integration Series*

# **AT THE EDGES OF CHRISTIANITY**

## **A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE**

*Jehovah's Witnesses, Unitarian Universalism, the New Apostolic  
Reformation, Unity, and the Word of Faith*

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*Some claim the Christian label. Some have moved beyond it entirely.  
All of them represent something Christianity produced when it pushed its own logic to an  
extreme.*

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## **Introduction -- When Christianity Reaches Its Edges**

Every tradition, pushed to its logical extreme, produces something its center would not recognize. Christianity has produced at its edges: a movement that claims God's true name and door-to-door evangelism as a religious obligation (Jehovah's Witnesses), a tradition that abandoned creed entirely in favor of a free search for truth (Unitarian Universalism), a movement that believes God is restoring the apostolic and prophetic offices to drive demons from entire geographic territories (New Apostolic Reformation), communities that brought New Thought directly into Sunday morning church format (Unity, Religious Science), and a global movement that teaches that faith and spoken declarations produce financial wealth as evidence of divine favor (Word of Faith / Prosperity Gospel).

Each of these represents a specific response to something the mainstream churches could not provide -- whether that is doctrinal certainty, theological freedom, direct felt power, practical manifestation tools, or community belonging. The Haligric practitioner reads each tradition with precision and compassion: what did this tradition correctly identify? What did it do with what it found? And where did the mechanism -- which was real -- get distorted by the framework placed around it?

## **Jehovah's Witnesses -- The Complete Picture**

Jehovah's Witnesses are among the most studied, most misrepresented, and most misunderstood religious communities in the world. The Haligric approach is to examine them with the same precision and respect applied to every other tradition in this library -- not to dismiss them and not to excuse what deserves examination.

## **Origins -- Charles Taze Russell and the Millerite Legacy**

Founded: 1870s Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania. Charles Taze Russell was born in 1852 in Pittsburgh to Presbyterian parents. He became deeply troubled by the doctrine of eternal hell in his teens -- finding it theologically incompatible with a God of love -- and began studying scripture independently, eventually connecting with Adventist groups whose biblical chronology predicted the imminent return of Christ.

Russell predicted Christ's invisible return in 1874 and the visible establishment of God's Kingdom on earth in 1914. When 1914 arrived without the expected visible kingdom, the interpretation shifted -- 1914 became the year Christ began ruling invisibly in heaven, with the end of the present world system imminent. Date predictions were subsequently made for 1925 and 1975, both passing without the expected Armageddon. The organization's response to failed predictions has consistently been reinterpretation rather than acknowledgment of error. After Russell's death in 1916, Joseph Franklin Rutherford ('Judge Rutherford') took control of the Watch Tower Society, centralized authority, introduced the name Jehovah's Witnesses in 1931, and developed many of the distinctive practices that characterize the movement today.

*HALIGRIC LENS: Russell's initial theological instinct -- that eternal hell is incompatible with divine love -- was correct and is shared by Haligricity. The problem was not the instinct but what was built around it: a centralized authority structure that replaced the Pope's infallibility with the Watch Tower Society's organizational infallibility, achieving the same result through different means.*

## **Theology -- What Witnesses Actually Believe**

Witness theology diverges from mainstream Christianity at several critical points. Jehovah -- the personal name of God as rendered in their New World Translation -- is the only true God.

Jesus Christ is not God but the first and greatest of Jehovah's creations -- identified with the Archangel Michael in his pre-human existence. The Holy Spirit is not a person but Jehovah's active force. The 144,000 mentioned in Revelation are the anointed class who will rule with Christ in heaven. The vast majority of Witnesses belong to the 'great crowd' who will survive Armageddon and live in paradise on a restored earth. As of 2025, Jehovah's Witnesses reported approximately 9.2 million active publishers (members) worldwide.

Blood transfusions are prohibited based on scriptural commands not to eat blood -- interpreted as prohibiting the introduction of blood from another person into one's own body. This doctrine has resulted in deaths, including children whose parents refused transfusions on their behalf. NOTE: In March 2026, the Watch Tower Society revised this policy to permit autologous blood donation -- members may now have their own blood drawn and stored for use in their own surgical procedures. This is the first significant modification to the blood doctrine in decades. Birthdays are not celebrated -- associated with pagan practices. Christmas, Easter, Halloween, and other holidays are not celebrated, their pagan origins understood as disqualifying them regardless of current cultural meaning.

## **The Watch Tower Society -- How Authority Works**

The Watch Tower Bible and Tract Society is the legal and organizational entity through which Jehovah's Witnesses operate globally. The Governing Body -- a small group of men at the organization's headquarters in Warwick, New York -- is understood as the Faithful and Discreet Slave of Matthew 24:45: the class appointed by God to provide spiritual food at the proper time. Their interpretations of scripture are understood as directed by Jehovah's spirit and are binding on all Witnesses worldwide.

The organizational structure flows from the Governing Body through Branch Committees in each country, to Circuit Overseers who oversee groups of congregations, to Congregation Elders (unpaid lay men) who manage each local congregation. There is no professional clergy. All Witnesses are expected to participate in the door-to-door ministry -- monthly reporting of field service hours is submitted to the congregation and reviewed. All publications are produced by the Watch Tower Society and used as the primary study materials in all Witness gatherings. Independent study of other religious materials, or forming conclusions that differ from Watch Tower publications, is strongly discouraged and can result in disciplinary action.

*HALIGRIC LENS: The Watch Tower Society achieved what every institutional religion attempts: the complete routing of all spiritual authority through a single organizational channel. The Governing Body's interpretations cannot be questioned any more than papal pronouncements could be questioned in pre-Reformation Catholicism. This is the institutional form of the dynamic that Haligrity identifies as the central wound of Western religion.*

## **Disfellowshipping and Shunning -- Community as Control**

Disfellowshipping was the formal exclusion of a Witness from the community for violations of Witness doctrine or morality. In August 2024, the Watch Tower Society announced that 'disfellowshipping' would be renamed 'removal from the congregation' and that removed members may now be greeted briefly at congregation meetings -- a partial softening of the previous policy, which prohibited all contact. Since March 2024, members may invite shunned individuals to congregation meetings or offer brief greetings at meetings, unless the individual is deemed to be an apostate. Norway withdrew state funding from Jehovah's Witnesses in 2024, ruling that the shunning practice constitutes psychological violence, particularly as applied to children.

Despite the terminological change, the core mechanism remains: a removed person loses all social relationships within the organization simultaneously -- friends, family, community.

Former members consistently describe this as a form of social death. The reinstating process -- written letters of repentance, a period of demonstrated changed behavior, a committee review -- typically takes months to years. The shunning mechanism is precisely calibrated to make the cost of independent spiritual authority prohibitive.

*HALIGRIC LENS: The Haligric practitioner recognizes this structure without judgment toward individual Witnesses, the vast majority of whom are sincere, generous, and genuinely motivated by love for their community and their God. The mechanism is not a feature of the theology -- it is a feature of the institutional control structure.*

## **Life After the Witnesses**

Former Jehovah's Witnesses represent one of the most studied groups of religious exiting in contemporary social science. The experience of leaving -- whether by choice or removal -- is consistently described as one of the most disorienting experiences a person can undergo. Everything that was certain becomes uncertain simultaneously. The skills for navigating a world outside the community may be significantly underdeveloped. Many former Witnesses experience profound spiritual disorientation -- not merely the loss of belief but the loss of an entire framework for understanding reality, meaning, and relationship.

*HALIGRIC LENS: This disorientation, understood through the Haligric lens, is the dark night before the direct recognition: the moment when every externally-provided answer has been taken away and the person is left with the only thing that was always there -- their own direct connection to the sacred, unmediated, uncontrolled, entirely their own. Haligrity is built for this moment.*

## **Unitarian Universalism -- The Great Synthesis**

Of all the traditions covered in three Christianity documents, Unitarian Universalism stands apart. It is the only major religious institution that does not require a specific creed, that explicitly honors multiple religious sources as valid paths, and that centers the free search for truth as its theological foundation. It is the institutional form of the recognition that Haligrity holds -- that no single tradition owns the truth, that the divine is accessible through many doors, and that the human being's own direct search is sacred.

## **The History -- From Servetus to the Present**

Founded: 1961 CE (merger of American Unitarian Association and Universalist Church of America). The Unitarian tradition traces to the 16th century Radical Reformation -- specifically to the anti-Trinitarian movements that questioned whether the doctrine of the Trinity was scriptural. Michael Servetus, a Spanish physician and theologian, published works denying the Trinity in 1531 and 1553. He was burned at the stake in Geneva in 1553 -- on the orders of John Calvin -- as a heretic. He became a martyr figure for the anti-Trinitarian movement.

The Universalist tradition -- the belief that all human beings will ultimately be saved, that a God of love cannot condemn any of his children to eternal punishment -- emerged separately in America in the late 18th century, led by John Murray and Hosea Ballou. Universalism was the first denomination in America to ordain a woman (Olympia Brown, 1863). The two traditions merged in 1961 to form the Unitarian Universalist Association, retaining both traditions' commitments to religious freedom, reason, and human dignity. Key figures in the Unitarian tradition include Ralph Waldo Emerson (who resigned from his Unitarian pulpit in 1832 because even Unitarianism was too doctrinally constraining), Henry David Thoreau, and Susan B. Anthony.

*HALIGRIC LENS: The Unitarian tradition produced the Transcendentalists -- the American philosophical movement that first brought Vedantic non-dual philosophy into*

*Western intellectual culture. The tradition that burned Servetus for questioning the Trinity produced, three centuries later, the people who would introduce the Bhagavad Gita to American readers. The sacred moves through even its most hostile containers.*

## **The 2024 Article II Revision -- New Shared Values**

In June 2024, at the virtual General Assembly of the Unitarian Universalist Association (June 20-23, 2024), delegates voted 80.2% in favor of adopting a new Statement of Shared Values -- replacing the Seven Principles and Six Sources that had guided UU theology since 1984-1985. The vote required a two-thirds majority; 80.2% voted yes. The change was the culmination of a multi-year review process required by UU bylaws every fifteen years.

The new framework centers LOVE as the animating force, with six Shared Values: EQUITY ('every person is inherently worthy and has the right to flourish with dignity, love, and compassion'), GENEROSITY, INTERDEPENDENCE, JUSTICE, PLURALISM, and TRANSFORMATION. The old Seven Principles are not prohibited -- congregations may continue to use and honor them -- but they no longer constitute the official UU covenant. Individual UUs and congregations are welcome to hold the Seven Principles as meaningful; the new Statement of Shared Values becomes the formal foundation of the UUA's work.

The revision had been controversial within the UU community. Some felt it adequately centered anti-racism and anti-oppressive action that the Seven Principles had not explicitly addressed. Others felt it de-emphasized reason and replaced elegant principle-based language with a more activist orientation. The 'Fourth Principle' -- a free and responsible search for truth and meaning -- does not appear by name in the new framework, though pluralism and free inquiry are embedded in its values. Despite the change, the document quotes the Seven Principles and Six Sources as they remain widely referenced within UU communities.

*HALIGRIC LENS: Whether the new framework is more or less Haligrical than the Seven Principles depends on where you look. Centering Love as the animating force is deeply resonant. Interdependence -- 'the web of all existence of which we are a part' -- carries the same recognition as the old Seventh Principle. What the new framework loses, compared to the old Principles, is the explicit 'free and responsible search for truth and meaning' as a named value -- that formulation was among the most precisely Haligrical statements in any institutional religious document.*

## **Six Sources of UU Theology**

UU theology has historically drawn from six explicitly named sources -- a level of formal multi-traditional honoring unique in institutional Western religion. These remain widely referenced within UU communities even as the 2024 revision updated the formal covenant: 1. Direct experience of that transcending mystery and wonder, affirmed in all cultures. 2. Words and deeds of prophetic women and men which challenge us to confront powers and structures of evil. 3. Wisdom from the world's religions which inspires us in our ethical and spiritual life. 4. Jewish and Christian teachings which call us to respond to God's love by loving our neighbors as ourselves. 5. Humanist teachings which counsel us to heed the guidance of reason and the results of science. 6. Spiritual teachings of Earth-centered traditions which celebrate the sacred circle of life.

*HALIGRIC LENS: Source Six -- Earth-centered traditions -- formally included within UU theology the indigenous sacred traditions that every other mainstream Western religion spent centuries trying to eradicate. Source Three -- wisdom from the world's religions -- is the entire Haligricality library held as a valid source of truth. Unitarian Universalism did institutionally what Haligricality does as a living practice: it honored the multiplicity without requiring reduction to a single tradition.*

## **The New Apostolic Reformation -- The Traveling Preachers**

Emerged: 1990s | Associated academics: C. Peter Wagner | Key figures: Lou Engle, Cindy Jacobs, Paula White. The New Apostolic Reformation (NAR) is a contemporary Evangelical movement identified and named by missiologist C. Peter Wagner of Fuller Theological Seminary in the 1990s. It is not a single denomination but a network of related movements and ministries centered on the belief that God is restoring the five-fold ministry offices of the early church: Apostles, Prophets, Evangelists, Pastors, and Teachers (Ephesians 4:11-13). Modern Apostles are understood to have the same authority as the biblical apostles: direct divine revelation, the authority to establish and oversee churches and movements, and the ability to perform signs and wonders. Prophets receive direct messages from God and deliver them to individuals, churches, cities, and nations.

NAR ministers hold large-scale events (The Call, Azusa Now, the Courage Tour) characterized by extended worship, prophetic declarations, healing prayer, and spiritual warfare. These events can draw hundreds of thousands of participants. The NAR has become increasingly intertwined with American political conservatism and the Trump movement. Paula White (Trump's spiritual advisor), House Speaker Mike Johnson, Vice President JD Vance, and other prominent figures have close ties to NAR networks. A 2024 scholarly poll found that Seven Mountains theology 'now dominates evangelical Christianity even beyond the portion of evangelicals in the charismatic/pentecostal camp.'

## **Spiritual Warfare Theology**

The NAR's most distinctive theological contribution is its highly developed spiritual warfare framework -- the teaching that demonic beings (territorial spirits) control specific geographic territories and that these spirits must be displaced through strategic prayer, prophetic declarations, and coordinated spiritual action before communities, cities, and nations can experience genuine transformation. The Seven Mountains of Culture -- business, government, media, arts and entertainment, education, family, and religion -- are the domains that NAR theology teaches must be 'occupied' by committed Christians for Christ's kingdom to be established on earth. This framework, sometimes called Dominionism or Kingdom Now theology, has significant political implications.

The prayer strategies associated with NAR spiritual warfare -- 24/7 prayer rooms, prayer walks through cities, coordinated prayer against specific spiritual entities over geographic areas -- represent a sophisticated understanding of the power of focused collective intention, though directed through a framework of combat and territorial control rather than healing and restoration.

**CONTROVERSY -- IHOPKC AND PROPHETIC AUTHORITY ABUSE:** The most significant scandal in recent NAR history directly implicates its core teaching. Mike Bickle, founder of the International House of Prayer Kansas City (IHOPKC) and one of the most influential Kansas City Prophets movement figures, was permanently separated from IHOPKC in December 2023. A February 2025 independent investigation found Bickle had committed sexual abuse and misconduct against at least 17 people, some of them minors, spanning decades. The report found he weaponized prophetic authority to coerce victims -- telling women that divine revelation had directed his actions and requiring victims to pray psalms of repentance after the abuse. IHOPKC Forerunner Church has since permanently closed. The Bickle case is the most documented example of how the NAR framework -- in which human leaders claim unquestionable divine authority -- creates conditions for severe abuse. The confusion of institutional power with divine sanction is exactly the dynamic the Haligrig framework identifies as the central wound of Western institutional religion.

*HALIGRIC LENS: The NAR correctly identified that focused collective intention affects the field of shared reality -- this is the quantum coherence that the Hundredth Monkey Effect documents and that ceremony in every indigenous tradition enacts. What the NAR*

*did with this recognition -- casting it in the framework of cosmic warfare, territorial demonic control, and the Seven Mountains dominion -- channeled real power through a lens of combat and control rather than harmony and restoration. The prayer is real. The framework around it shapes what it produces.*

## **Unity Church and Religious Science -- New Thought in Church Form**

Unity and Religious Science are the institutional expressions of the New Thought movement -- what happens when the philosophy that consciousness creates reality, that affirmative prayer works, and that the divine lives within every person is organized into a community with Sunday services, music, pastoral care, and a congregation. They are the closest thing to a Haligricity church that currently exists.

UNITY CHURCH: Founded 1889, Kansas City, Missouri | Headquarters: Unity Village, Missouri. Charles Fillmore and Myrtle Page met in Kansas City in the 1880s. Myrtle was suffering from tuberculosis and attended a New Thought lecture where she heard the phrase 'I am a child of God and therefore I do not inherit sickness.' She took this statement as a literal truth, repeated it in prayer and meditation over the following two years, and recovered completely. Her healing became the foundation event of Unity. Unity theology teaches that God is Absolute Good, present everywhere, including within every human being. Jesus Christ is understood as the pattern for human development -- the Christ consciousness that Jesus embodied is the divine potential within every person. Prayer is affirmative -- spoken to the God within, affirming truth rather than petitioning an external authority. The Daily Word -- Unity's devotional publication -- reaches millions of readers across denominational boundaries.

*HALIGRIC LENS: Myrtle Fillmore's healing is a documented example of what Haligricity teaches about the relationship between inner recognition and physical reality. She did not petition an external God for healing. She recognized a truth about her own nature -- that as a child of the divine she did not inherit sickness -- and held that recognition consistently until her body reflected it. This is the Observer Effect operating through sustained conscious intention. It is Heka. It is Haligricity.*

RELIGIOUS SCIENCE: Founded 1927 | Key text: The Science of Mind (1926). Ernest Holmes was a self-educated New Thought philosopher who published The Science of Mind in 1926 -- one of the most comprehensive systematic presentations of New Thought philosophy ever written. Holmes drew from Emerson, Christian Science, Theosophy, Vedanta, and comparative religion to construct a unified metaphysical system. His central principle -- the Law of Mind in Action -- teaches that mind (consciousness) is the fundamental reality, that thoughts held consistently in mind produce corresponding conditions in the physical world. Spiritual Mind Treatment has a five-step structure: Recognition (God is), Unification (I am one with God), Realization (therefore this specific truth is already spiritually established), Thanksgiving, and Release (letting go into the law).

*HALIGRIC LENS: The Science of Mind is the most systematically developed Western philosophical account of what the Observer Effect, the DNA Phantom Effect, and the Hundredth Monkey Effect scientifically document -- that consciousness affects material reality through a mechanism not yet fully understood but consistently observable. Holmes arrived at this conclusion through philosophy and comparative religion decades before quantum physics began to confirm it. Haligricity stands in this lineage directly -- and names it more completely.*

## **Silent Unity -- The Living Practice**

Silent Unity is the direct living continuation of the healing experience that founded Unity: within a year of Myrtle Fillmore's own recovery, word of her prayer practice had spread



widely enough that people she had never met began sending her their own requests for prayer. In 1890, Charles and Myrtle formalized this into the Society of Silent Help -- renamed Silent Unity the following year -- and it has operated continuously ever since, making it one of the oldest continuously running prayer ministries in the United States.

A telephone line was added in 1907; by September 1929, the ministry had expanded to genuine 24-hour, 7-day operation from a dedicated prayer room -- a prayer vigil that has run without interruption for close to a century since. Every prayer request, whether received by phone, letter, or online, is placed in the prayer vigil chapel and held in continuous prayer by rotating prayer associates for thirty days. The ministry now answers roughly 1.3 to 2 million requests annually, offered to people of any faith or none, with no cost and no religious requirement attached -- callers are greeted simply with 'Silent Unity. How may we pray with you?'

*HALIGRIC LENS: Silent Unity is Unity's clearest answer to a living self-care and wellness practice. Myrtle Fillmore's healing was not treated as a private, one-time event to be admired from a distance, but as a working method meant to be extended to anyone who asked. A century of continuous, unbroken practice is itself a form of evidence -- not proof of the theological claims about prayer's mechanism, but proof that the community built around those claims found something durable enough to sustain across five generations without interruption.*

## **The Word of Faith / Prosperity Gospel**

Emerged: 1950s-1970s | Key figures: Kenneth Hagin, Kenneth Copeland, Creflo Dollar, Benny Hinn, Joel Osteen. The Word of Faith movement traces primarily to Kenneth Hagin (1917-2003) of Tulsa, Oklahoma, who claimed to have had multiple visions of Jesus and who developed the theological framework that came to define the movement. Hagin drew heavily from E.W. Kenyon, a New England preacher influenced by New Thought and Christian Science in the late 19th century. The core principles: faith is a force (a literal spiritual force that moves in the realm of the spirit), words are containers of faith (spoken words release or block the spiritual force of faith), and confession produces possession (speaking a desired outcome with faith causes it to manifest in physical reality). Health and financial prosperity are the covenant rights of the believer -- provisions already purchased by Christ's atonement and available through faith confession.

The movement spread globally through Hagin's Rhema Bible Training College and through his most prominent student, Kenneth Copeland. From Copeland the teaching spread through Creflo Dollar, Benny Hinn, Joyce Meyer, and eventually -- in a more polished, psychologically accessible form -- through Joel Osteen, whose Lakewood Church in Houston is the largest congregation in America.

**THE MECHANISM IS REAL:** The Word of Faith tradition identified something genuine. The relationship between inner state and outer circumstance is real. The power of spoken affirmation to reshape consciousness and thereby affect material experience is real. The New Thought lineage from which the tradition draws -- whether acknowledged or not -- documented this mechanism with philosophical rigor. Quantum physics, psychoneuroimmunology, and the neuroscience of neuroplasticity have begun to provide biological mechanisms for what the tradition describes spiritually.

The problem is not the mechanism. The problem is the theological framework placed around it. When the mechanism is attributed to faith in an external God whose covenant provisions can be released through specific verbal formulas, the practitioner who does not manifest the desired result has only one explanation available: insufficient faith. They have failed. This is the precise inversion of the mechanism's actual operation. The framework of external divine provision, faith as technique, and tithing as the price of prosperity corrupts the mechanism

precisely by keeping the practitioner's awareness focused outward on a God who is withholding rather than inward on the recognition that is already complete.

"Name it and claim it. Blab it and grab it." -- Critical shorthand for Word of Faith teaching. "The prosperity gospel has killed more people than cancer. It has destroyed more finances than gambling. It has ruined more marriages than adultery. It has devastated more spiritual lives than atheism." -- John Piper (Reformed theologian critique from within Christianity)

*HALIGRIC LENS: Haligrity holds the mechanism -- the creative power of conscious intention, spoken with the full alignment of feeling, thinking, speaking, and doing -- without the external-God framework that makes it extractive. The Varessence is not a formula for getting God to deliver. It is a technology for aligning the whole self with the recognition of what is already true. The difference is not cosmetic. It is the difference between a person who believes they are worthy of the divine's provision and a person who knows they are the divine's expression.*

## **The Haligrity Synthesis -- What Each Tradition Carries**

The Haligrity practitioner does not dismiss any of the traditions covered in this document. Each carries something real -- something that emerged because people needed it, because they were searching for the divine with the tools and frameworks available to them in their specific historical and cultural context.

**JEHOVAH'S WITNESSES** -- What it carries: Devotion, community, scriptural rigor. What it obscures: Self-authority; shunning as control.

**UNITARIAN UNIVERSALISM** -- What it carries: Free search, synthesis, human dignity. What it obscures: Sometimes lacks depth of practice.

**NEW APOSTOLIC REFORMATION** -- What it carries: Collective intention, prophetic voice. What it obscures: Combat framework, territorial control.

**UNITY CHURCH** -- What it carries: Affirmative prayer, healing recognition. What it obscures: Sometimes overly positive.

**RELIGIOUS SCIENCE** -- What it carries: Systematic metaphysics, treatment practice. What it obscures: Can become overly intellectual.

**WORD OF FAITH** -- What it carries: The mechanism -- spoken word and intention. What it obscures: External God, extraction, blame.

*HALIGRIC LENS: The Haligrity practitioner who has moved through or alongside any of these traditions carries something from each one -- the devotion of the Witnesses without the shunning, the free search of the UU without the formlessness, the collective intention of the NAR without the warfare, the affirmative prayer of Unity without the toxic positivity, the systematic metaphysics of Religious Science without the intellectualism, the spoken creative power of Word of Faith without the extraction. Haligrity is what you find when you take everything these traditions identified and strip away everything they placed around it that kept people from finding what they were actually looking for. Grand Rising.*